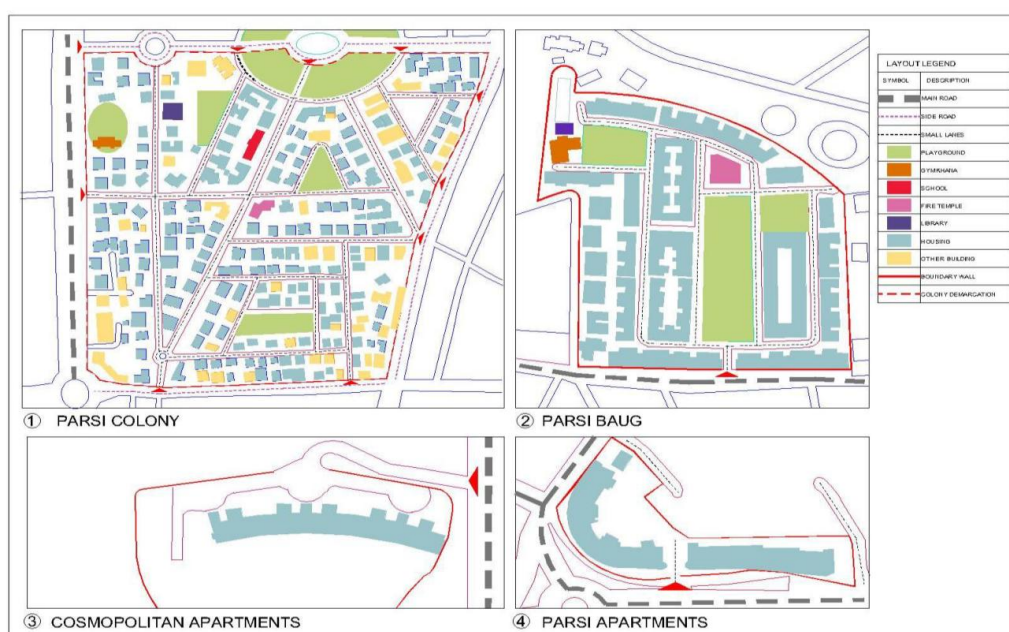


How has the affordability of Parsi Baugs influenced patterns of community living, cultural preservation, and socio-economic diversity within the Parsi population of Mumbai?

Research Paper By Zaha Irani

Section 1: Introduction

The Parsi Baugs of Mumbai represent a unique community housing model, founded on the centralised idea of giving secure and modest yet affordable accommodations under one roof only to the Parsi community members (Zoroastrians.net, 2013; Parsikhabar.net, 2013). Baugs emerged in the first half of the 20th century and arose out of philanthropic initiatives of those wealthy Parsi families that were able to donate large amount of land to be built an entire Baugs, with the most prominent figure being the Bai Jerbai Wadia who contributed to the creation of these residential complexes (Wikipedia, 2024; Times of India, 2024). This model has proven to be a lifeline support system to the current population of the Parsis in Mumbai not only as an avenue of physical shelter but also as a source of institutionalized provision of living space that enables the community of today to live as a group and ensures they preserve their culture and pass it to the next generation (Times of India, 2024; Parsikhabar.net, 2013).



Sehgal, H., & Toscano, W. A. (2021). *Neighborhood exposures and blood pressure outcomes:*

A cross-sectional environmental study among 19–53-years-old Parsis in Mumbai.

International Journal of Environmental Research and Public Health, 18(16), 8594.

<https://doi.org/10.3390/ijerph18168594>

Usually, Parsi Baugs are built as self-sustaining, self-sufficient communities that have gardens, club houses, market places, fire temples and recreations facilities, all of which develop a strong sense of community and isolate residents against the pressures of city life (Parsikhabar.net, 2013; Wikipedia, 2024). These colonies have been characterized as being mini-cities where the Parsi way of life is treasured thoroughly based on Zoroastrianism values and traditions (Parsikhabar.net, 2013). The designs, green areas, and planning of Baugs incorporate the specialization of heritage and modernity to transform a living situation that best suits the practical needs of residential areas as well as the cultural fantasy of the neighborhood (Hindustan Times, 2023; Wikipedia, 2025).

In the present-day Mumbai, the functions of Baugs have become more than affordable housing; the Baugs are as essential in combating the loss of Parsi culture and population as the rising of the flames. With continued decline in the number of people living in the neighborhood and the skyrocketing real estate value of the city, the accessibility, and exclusiveness of Baugs have also assumed a new importance in securing socio-economic safety in the community, and collective identification (Wikipedia, 2024; Times of India, 2024). Through this research paper, the researcher examines the role the affordability of Parsi Baugs has played in shaping the lives of Parsis in Mumbai in three distinct ways; patterns of community housing, preservation of culture and socio-economic diversity.

This thesis is an exploration of both historical origins and contemporary issues of Parsi Baugs through an exploration of housing policies, the role of social dynamics, and the complex paths of the past. Findings in this study will also give insight into the seemingly contradictory nature of material and intangible advantages of affordable community housing

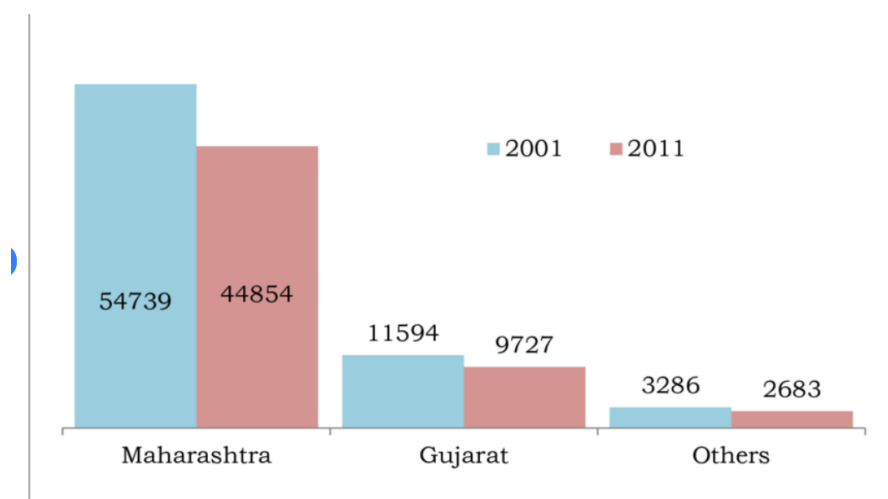
and provide suggestions on achieving long-term sustainability of this form of urban community (Zoroastrians.net, 2013; Parsikhabar.net, 2013).

Section 2: Historical Perspective

2.1 Origins and Early Development

An interesting example of this can be seen in the Parsi Baugs of Mumbai, which are an original disposition of the housing demands of this community in the early part of the 20th century as a part of a wider urban reform movement that attempted to relieve the congestion and poor sanitation conditions of Mumbai in its aftermath(Parsikhabar.net, 2013; Azure Sky Follows, 2024). This first urban sprawl was catalyzed by the Dadar-Matunga-Wadala-Sion scheme proposed in 1899-1900 by the British colonial government in order to decongest the city center with the primary concern being health and sanitation (Wikipedia, 2025). In this city design the Parsis were able to obtain exclusive living areas to preserve their religious and cultural identity with Mancherji Edulji Joshi being instrumental in brokering land assignments and urban design of the Dadar Parsi colony (Azure Sky Follows, 2024; Wikipedia, 2025).

This was a first step to harmonize urban modernization and community tradition, as the facility was a wide, ventilated, and green neighbourhood court being specifically developed to house the Parsi people (Azure Sky Follows, 2024). The colony included low-rise structures, parks, and green spaces that were further complemented to promote a healthy living environment with communal amenities comprising fire temples and social clubs that virtually made the colony a mini-city of Mumbai (Wikipedia, 2025; Parsikhabar.net, 2013).



1.3. States with highest Parsi population in India, Census 2001 and 2011

Unisa, S., & Bhagat, R. B. (2017). *Impact assessment and evaluation of Jiyo Parsi scheme* (Technical Report). Government of India. Figure 1.3: States with highest Parsi population in India, Census 2001 and 2011 gives a bar chart of Parsi distribution compared between census data of 2001 and 2011 across the states of India. Maharashtra--particularly of Mumbai--becomes the main centre, other states (such as Gujarat, Delhi, and West Bengal) having much smaller and deteriorating Parsi communities. This number points to the demographic shrinkage of the community in the country and its intensive localization in Maharashtra, which identifies the significance of urban Baugs as cultural bastions.

2.2 Philanthropic Foundations and Expansion

Simultaneous with the government led initiative, Parsi philanthropists, especially Bai Jerbai Wadia who was the great-grandmother of glamorous industrialist Nusli Wadia, moved to large-scale privately funded housing projects taking place between 1908 and 1956. Bai Jerbai had bought into large land estates and acquired 6-acre Nowroz Baug in Lalbaug, which was later to be jointly developed with her family trusts 13 acres Cusrow Baug in Colaba and 7 acres Ness Baug in Nana Chowk (Times of India, 2024). These Baugs consisted of apartments which were of multiple stories and were built to house poor and middle-class

Parsis with over 1,500 flats on more than 35 acres of the most desirable land of South Mumbai (Times of India, 2024; Parsikhabar.net, 2013).

Cusrow Baug designed by an English architect Claude Batley and constructed between 1934 and 1959 is an example of this cycle of philanthropy. It also had its buildings designed to allow variations in community facilities such as Zoroastrian fire temple, sports club, and gymnasium, thus reflecting the reflection of integration of cultural, religious and recreational facility needs within a single housing complex (Wikipedia, 2024). These Baugs did not sell their homes instead they rented them, thereby maintaining affordability and at the same time ensuring long-term sustainability of the community through the bargaining of leases through charitable trusts like the Bombay Parsi Punchayet (BPP) and the wadia trusts (times of India, 2024).

2.3 Urban Identity and Community Preservation

With the growth of the city of Mumbai Baug's became conspicuous bastions of community and cultural sanctity. The strategy is to maintain the facade of the Parsi social identity within the in-rush of the urban civilisation, as the neo-classical and colonial style of architecture had been well conserved and complemented with beautiful gardens and common spaces (Parsikhabar.net, 2013; Times of India, 2024). The population of DU Pilot Parsi Colony is estimated to be 15,000, and it is one of the largest Zoroastrian communities in the world today and a dynamic manifestation of the urban Parsi community (Wikipedia, 2025).

These Baugs are still used to host religious as well as cultural programs and social gatherings, which re-affirm Parsi traditions and community lines (Parsikhabar.net, 2013). These provide an autonomous scenario where diverse generations exchange feelings and coalesce day by day, as part of the cycle of handing down cultural values, language, and customs that are necessary to society. Concurrently, this is coupled with new pressures due to

demographic and real estate value increases, as the protectorate workforce has been plagued by traditionally low-pay high-rent living conditions, that are in danger of being jeopardized by the same historic forces (Times of India, 2024; Parsikhabar.net, 2013).

Section 3: Affordability and Housing Policies

The affordability element of the Parsi Baugs in Mumbai cannot be overlooked in its influence on the society in terms of housing. These Baugs are specifically constructed to serve the purpose of long-term economical housing to Parsi people and mostly the less affluent and middle-income ones. These housing colonies were created and then managed because of a very distinct union of charity-mindedness, community control and government policy models that allowed affordability to be maintained in an otherwise expensive urban housing market (Parsikhabar.net, 2013; Times of India, 2024).

3.1 Management of Trusts and Governance

The Bombay Parsi Punchayet (BPP), a charitable trust founded in 1672, has been pivotal in most of the land acquisition, building of structure, and maintaining rent and tenancy relations within the Baugs (Times of India, 2024; Azure Sky Follows, 2024). The BPP in collaboration with other trusts like N.N. Wadia and R.N. Wadia Trusts manages the giving of flats on the basis of community aspects, rent control and maintaining the infrastructures of the colony (Parsikhabar.net, 2013). This management has kept the rents of these Baugs well below the normal market rates in the city thereby ensuring that the apartments are affordable to Parsis of all economic strata.

As opposed to being outright ownership, these Baugs are run on a lease or leave-and-license basis, and in many cases with an expressed tenure of 99 years or more. This type of system avoids any speculative sales and ensures that there is continuity in residency and the community (Azure Sky Follows, 2024). The steps undertaken by the BPP and the affiliated

trusts such as precluding commercialization of the flats by making it accessible to the community members only in need makes it affordable.

3.2 Rent Control and Affordability

The housing market of Mumbai has a long record of high prices and dearth of supply but rents in Parsi Baugs are highly regulated. Indicatively, rents in certain Baugs, Cusrow Baug and Ness Baug are capped at monthly rates of between INR 1,000 and INR 10,000, in spite of apartments competing to garner high security deposit refunds of crores, to secure apartments (Times of India, 2024). Such a structure guarantees a long-term affordability of the tenants and it helps trusts to maintain building upkeep and community-related activities.

The security deposits will serve as a financial security but not incentive to the trusts as in the case of open market transaction. This hybrid model allows marrying exclusivity and affordability, although its affordability puts some strain on social-economic tensions since wealthier Parsis are able to deposit more but still access capped rents (Times of India, 2024).

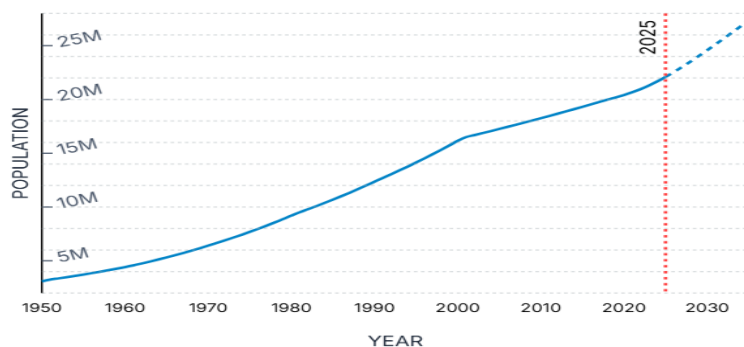
3.3 Effect on social-economic diversity

The affordability concept maintains social economic diversity whereby the range of different income families is represented in the Baugs which serves as a miniature representation of the wider Parsi community. The low-income earners enjoy reduced costs of rent, communal amenities as well as participatory governance, and the rich donate in forms of deposits and social interaction, which continue to make up the community life (Parsikhabar.net, 2013). Diversity is part of the characteristic of the Baugs and has to do with the liveliness and strength of the community life.

With the increase in property values in South Mumbai, however, the moguls within the community have started to cash in on Baugs by depositing hefty sums on acquisition of bigger flats, which can give skewing to access. This fragile balance between inclusiveness

and distribution of wealth is an issue that concerns the administrators of trusts (Times of India, 2024).

Mumbai Population



World Population Review. (2025). Mumbai population 2025.

<https://worldpopulationreview.com/cities/india/mumbai>

To get a clearer picture on these tendencies, it is interesting to plot population changes, indices of housing affordability and the growth of real estate prices across Mumbai and compare them to the stability of population amongst Parsee (World Population Review, 2025; Times of India, 2024). This graph reflects the explosive growth of the population of Mumbai since the year 1950, and a decreasing number of Parsis, and the effect that Baugs have had in shielding the community against the rising rental rates in the rest of Mumbai.

The comparison of the rent index in Parsi Baugs and overall rising prices of real estate property in Mumbai shows how well the strategy of philanthropic trust management and rent control has worked to make the process of getting a flat as affordable as possible (World Population Review, 2025).

Section 4: Parsi Baugs - Community Living Patterns

The even smaller nature of the Parsi Baugs in Mumbai has gone far beyond the affordable housing estate; the Baugs are self-contained micro communities of the Parsee people with strong bonding, the mutual support system, and the cultural life as a community. These Baugs are the vital community centers in which the residents conduct a variety of activities and are given various facilities that facilitate intergenerational interaction and collective identity enhancement (Parsikhabar.net, 2013).

4.1 Social Infrastructure and Infrastructure Facilities

The Baugs are referred to as mini-cities as they have all round infrastructure. As an example, Cusrow Baug is over 84,000 square yard in size with over 600 families inside and such facilities as a gymnasium, football field, gardens, a fire temple, grocery shops, and a club house (Wikipedia, 2024; Parsikhabar.net, 2013). Equally large, the Dadar Parsi Colony has over 15, 000 residents, a number of schools, swimming pools, playgrounds, libraries, gymkhanas etc. and provided with the breathing lungs by Sir Mancherji Joshi- green gardens that do the trick in the crowded urban scenario (Azure Sky Follows, 2024; Parsikhabar.net, 2013).

Through these amenities, not only development of recreational activities and fitness take place but religious and cultural social gatherings are also shaped, which are essential in any society. The presence of the fire temples, that are found in a number of Baugs, including the Karani Agiary in Cusrow Baug, help to establish vital spiritual homing points, where there is repeated involvement in worship and community communal prayer (Parsikhabar.net, 2024; Times of India, 2024).

These residents have access to services like home delivery of goods, local traders, clinics, and other social activities organized by social welfare associations like the Cusrow

Baug United Sports & Welfare League that includes educational classes on religion, sports tournaments, and other similar activities (Parsikhabar.net, 2013). Such characteristics are important to the extent that residents and especially aging citizens and their families develop a sense of being in a nurturing environment.

4.2 Union and Belonging

Evening scenes in the Baugs are usually full of life as people are going out on walks, children playing, and people meeting in common zones, something unusual in a city environment (Parsikhabar.net, 2013). This community is a part of Baugs identity, where neighbours can often know one another personally and mutual care networks arise automatically.

In times of crises like COVID-19 lockdowns, Baugs showed incredible unity where the residents created their support systems to the vulnerable groups such as the elderly and the infirm (Times of India 2024). This community ethos maintains customs of mutual co-operation and has its origins in the Zoroastrian ethical code that focused on community good and charity.

Although the general issue of inclusion that occurs in Baugs is rather positive, the new socio-economic dynamics, which involve the entry of wealthier Parsis capable of paying large lump sums on flats, create a subtle dilemma that can disrupt the social balances (Parsikhabar.net, 2024). Nevertheless, as a whole, the procedures of trust management and governance attempt to find a compromise between tradition and modern reality to keep Baugs as the lively social space.

4.3 Patterns of Community Living in Parsi Baugs

The Parsi Baugs of the city of Mumbai are not mere residential enclosures, they are thriving community playgrounds that grant a strong sense of belonging, group identification

and socio-cultural continuity. Dubbed as mini-cities, these Baugs offer plenty of complexes and social amenities that regulate community living, which favors the maintenance of the Parsi tradition and values (Parsikhabar.net, 2013).

4.4 Interpersonal relations and communitarian belonging

The arrangement of architecture promotes a social-interactive life with neighbours in support of each other. Instead, the overall effects of living in such communities are usually social, as residents tend to gather in gardens, clubhouses, and temples and strengthen intergenerational ties (Parsikhabar.net, 2013). These interactions build a support system in which neighbours support elderly residents, help them share resources, and unite against any crisis like the COVID-19 pandemic when Baugs have been able to provide support to vulnerable members of the houses (Times of India, 2024).

In Baugs, children are nurtured in a community that provides not only cultural teachings, sports and social values taught at schools, religious classes, but also informally through daily activities based on close proximity and the sharing of facilities (Wikipedia, 2024).

Nonetheless, there are changing dynamics of the social fabric in Baugs as the affluent Parsis are able to enter or even move within such societies. Trustees of Baugs are struggling to find a compromise between inclusivity and financial aspects of increasing property values and prevalence of security deposits that can make it inaccessible to less wealthier residents (Times of India, 2024).

4.5 Communal Living to mastering cultural preservation

The Baugs are those who watch over the Parsi culture, symbolism and religious practice. The presence of Fire temples as spiritual centers and religious classes within the community help to nurture the younger generations in terms of knowing and adhering to the

Zoroastrianism knowledge (Parsikhabar.net, 2013). Community identity and unity can be ensured through ceremonialistic celebrations of Parsi feasts held collectively in the Baugs like Navroz, Kordad Sal and Pateti (Azure Sky Follows, 2024).

The holistic development of the community within the Baugs include the preservation of cultural nature of the Parsis which would continue to exist amid the backdrop of the increasing multiethnic and urban city of Mumbai. The give and take between the community living and culture retention is a flagship aspect of Baugs that negotiate the identity and contemporary city living.

Section 5: Socio-Economic Diversity in Parsi Baugs

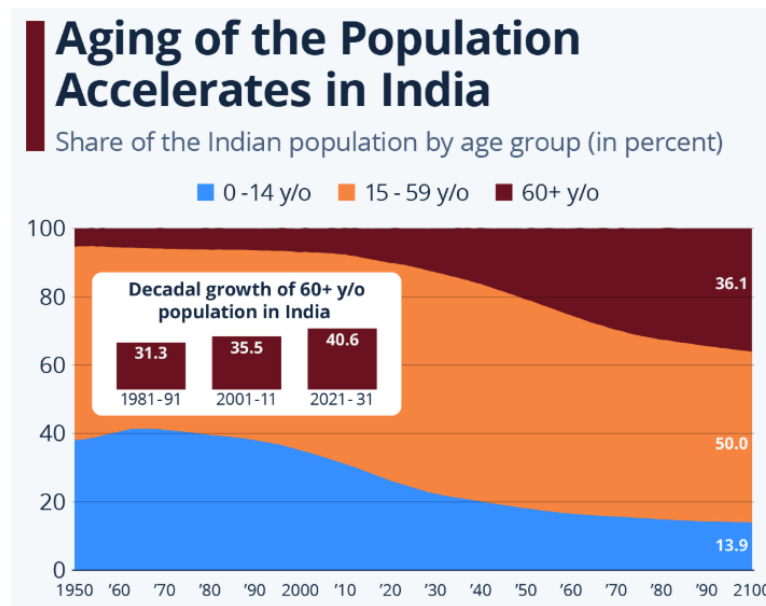
The Parsi Baugs on the surface are boxes of affordable housing built to provide members of the Parsi community who had lesser means with an affordable home. But as a matter of fact the Baugs have become a patchwork of many contradictions that manifest itself in a sophisticated social economic hierarchy within the Parsi Community in Mumbai. This bit of socio-economic mix is coupled with entry politics, regulatory mechanisms of trust, antecedence, and newly developing market conditions of Baugs (Shroff & Castro, 2011).

5.1 Demographic and Social Indicators

The latest demographic studies have noted a graying and ageing Parsi population in Mumbai with a total Parsi figure reducing after 1991, when the population was estimated to be over 53,000, to an approximate rate of 46,557 as per 2001 with further declines expected in the following decades (Shroff & Castro, 2011). The low rates of fertility (0.89 in 2001), advanced median age, the rising number of singles and the old population in the society are some of the key indicators of the socio-economic issues (Shroff & Castro, 2011).

Such demographic tensions have dangerous socio-economic effects within Baugs since lower family sizes, lower proportions of younger residents, portend less generational

resupply, lack of community members in social clubs and religious classes, and as growing pressures on the elder care and social support networks (Shroff at Castro, 2011).



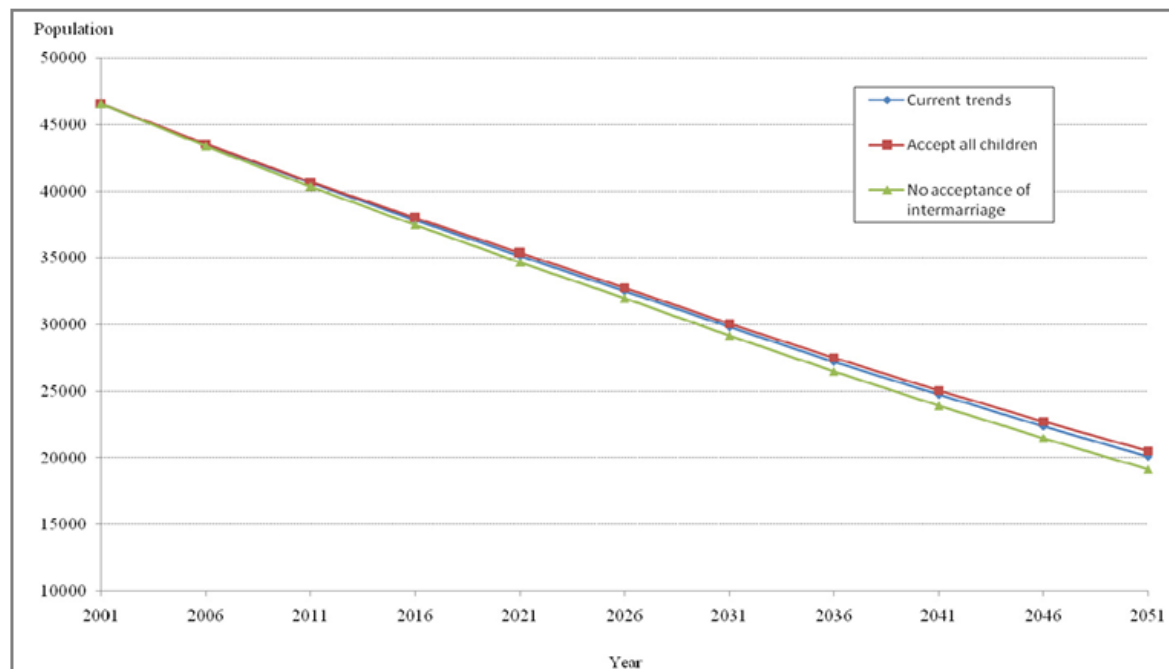
Buchholz, K. (2025, June 11). *Aging of the population accelerates in India*. Statista.

<https://www.statista.com/chart/30958/share-of-age-groups-in-indian-population/>

This graph shows that the age of the population in India is changing: in 2025 a larger proportion of the population (about 11 percent) will be 60 and older, and the numbers are expected to reach more than 20 percent by the middle of the century. The sharp rise indicates the urgency of policy and infrastructure responses to aging issues not only at the national level but also particularly to culturally distinct and declining groups such as the Parsis.

Migration rates also influence the socio-economic composition with more financially well off Parsi moving back or shifting to Baugs making a huge investment in the form of deposits and up-grading housing standards, whereas other less financially stable households continue living on rent subsidies which they inherited (Times of India, 2024). This has

formed a dualistic formation of the Baugs integrating old fashioned members of the community and the upward mobility groups.



Shroff, Z., & Castro, M. C. de. (2011). *The potential impact of intermarriage on the population decline of Parsis of Mumbai*. *Demographic Research*, 25(17), 543–568.

<https://www.demographic-research.org/volumes/vol25/17/25-17.pdf>

The next graph, reproduced by Shroff & Castro (2011), represents the population of Parsis in Mumbai in 2001 to 2051 depending on three possible directions: trends of existing demographic rate, acceptance of children born out of intermarriage, and non-acceptance of the intermarriage. These situations highlight the population contraction issue, which has a direct effect on the socio-economic life and sustainability of Baugs.

The Parsi Baugs are, at one level, affordable housing made available to the less-affluent Parsis in a magnanimous gesture of the community, but the living complexes have today become a veritable mosaic which shows the multiplicity of socio-economic classes

within the Parsi population in Mumbai. This socio-economic dispersion goes hand in hand with entry process, governance of trusts, historical backgrounds, and the emergence of markets around Baugs (Shroff & Castro, 2011).

5.2 Economic stratification and Access

Traditionally, Baugs were established to accommodate financially disadvantaged Parsis however, through the years, people of varied economic background have taken up lodgings in such communities. Distribution of the flats is done by Bombay Parsi Punchayet other trusts in terms of rent control or lease-cum-security deposit that are known to segregate Parsis but in less obvious echelons based on affordability (Parsikhabar.net, 2013). Rental fees are affordable and entry deposits to more spacious and preferred apartments can be quite hefty, thus creating a socio-economic gradient where the richer Parsi people stand in a better position with regard to available housing over the more attractive housing locations (Times of India, 2024).

Such stratification also leads to the creation of micro-segments in Baugs:

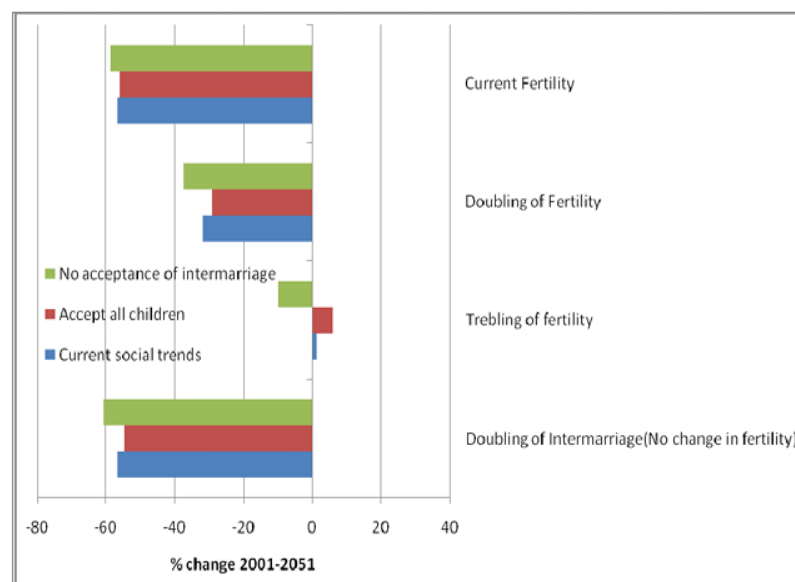
- Residents considered as lower-income people, residing on Tiny flats with little deposits,
- Families of moderate income, who strike a balance between deposits and inexpensive rents,
- Those with better living standards who have more money to deposit to an agent to take up bigger rooms in choice Baugs (Times of India, 2024).

On the one hand, such diversity enhances the life of the community by raising the level of interaction, but on the other hand, it creates socio-economic conflicts as the newcomers are more affluent so they can affect the governance rules and social values. Still,

the collective trust models strive to reach a balance, as they control the transfers and protect the initial affordable purpose of

Such demographic pressures have severe social-economic consequences within Baugs, where lower household size and a younger population equates to reduced generational turnover, community involvement in social clubs and religious schools, and increased services that require the elderly and social safety nets (Shroff & Castro, 2011).

Migration patterns also influence the socio-economic composition where more affluent Parsis either returned or migrated back to Baugs and were investing large capital in deposits and upgrade of their homes, but their less wealthy relatives continue to bask on the pre-existing rent-subsidy (Times of India, 2024). This dynamism brings to being the duality in the Baugs, which is between the traditional community members and the upwardly mobile segments.



Shroff, Z., & Castro, M. C. de. (2011). *The potential impact of intermarriage on the population decline of Parsis of Mumbai*. *Demographic Research*, 25(17), 543–568.

<https://www.demographic-research.org/volumes/vol25/17/25-17.pdf>

The projection by Shroff & Castro (2011) as shown in the following graph represents the Parsi population in Mumbai in 2001 and in 2051 (under three modalities, the actual projection, where children of intermarriage are accepted and two others where they are not). These two scenarios highlight the issue of shrinking in population, a direct implication on the social-economic life and sustenance of Baugs.

Section 6: The Governance and Management of Parsi Baugs

The processes of governance and management of the Parsi Baugs in Mumbai is a sensitive and crucial determinant that directly affects its affordability, maintenance, groups cohesion and longevity. The majority of Baugs are ran by and controlled by charitable trusts and panchayats like the Bombay Parsi Punchayet (BPP), which now take over the provision of housing welfare of the Parsis. Such trusts are stewards trying to facilitate the twin goals of social welfare and heritage conservation against the operational issues created by a changing city region (Times of India, 2019; Parsikhabar.net, 2013).

6.1 The role of Charitable Trusts and Panchayats

The largest private citizenship landowner in the Parsi Baugs of Mumbai is the Bombay Parsi Punchayet, which has about 5,500 houses (or flats) in 18 colonies across the grouping such as Cusrow Baug, Rustom Baug, Ness Baug and Jerbai Baug (Times of India, 2019). The major aim of the Punchayet is to give low and middle income Parsis of a secure and affordable housing. It has to collect rental, maintain its properties, resolve cases related to tenants and renewing their leases, with little budget of its own given the demanded low rents and the increase in paying government lease rents (Times of India, 2019).

Besides the BPP, there are none-the-less other family trusts or community panchayats that manage the smaller Baugs through an equally similar pattern of philanthropy and community governance, but in a semi-autonomous manner. Their governing philosophy is to

pay more attention to the community needs and conserving their culture rather than to profitability (Parsikhabar.net, 2013).

6.2 Lease Renewals and Government Challenges

The dilemma that faces one of the greatest governance issues is due to the expiry of long term government land leases that many of the Baugs are seated on. The majority of leases granted on a 99 year term in early 20th century either lapsed or are approaching lapse (Times of Indian, 2019). The new policies implemented by the government in leasing renewal have significantly burdened these trusts of charity with high financial expectations such as the costly lease rent valuations and penalties in case of late application to renew the leases.

As an example, the BPP was recently required to pay more than 35 crores to renew leases of Rustom Baug, Jer Baug and Ness Baugh and this was a burden considering their charitable rent regimes with tenants paying nominal amounts of rent often not enough to even cover basic maintenance, statutory charges etc. (Times of India, 2019). This has resulted in the threat of litigation and vehement argument on the side of trustees to have Baugs reclassified as charitable social housing that is exempted to such enormous taxes. Once the leasing contracts expire, there is a fear that the future legal basis of tenant occupation and the feasibility of Baugs as the affordable housing colonies becomes a problem (Times of India, 2019).

6.3 Rebuilding and citizen reaction

With increased urban pressures and the deterioration of infrastructures, at least one proposal has been floated to rebuild old Baugs into snazzy high-rise structures that feature swimming pools, gyms, multi-purpose halls and the like (Times of India, 2013). Such redevelopment is set to address the lack of housing and to update old and inefficient facilities but has been met with fierce controversy by the locals.

It is claimed that redevelopment jeopardizes the heritage and the special atmosphere of the Baugs with its quaint gardens, low-rise architecture, and interpersonal interactions (Parsiana Magazine, 2013). People worry that increased-rise buildings will consume open areas, make maintenance unaffordable to poorer citizens, and destroy the social balance (Parsikhabar.net, 2013).

On the other hand, the advocates would mention the utilitarian need to meet the increased housing needs through includes modern amenities, and living standards of Parsis. The new outlook of governance as portrayed by the recent resolution of the Bombay Parsi Punchayet to end the old housing scheme and seek new forms of development has seen a trade-off between tradition and development (Times of India, 2013).

6.4 Community participation/governance dilemmas

The community should greatly be involved in the running of Baugs. There is regular consultation and decision-making amongst trustees, tenants, and community organisations although there are issues around transparency, management of conflicts, and alignment of different socio-economic interests. The strengthening role of wealthy Parsis and outsider capital has created complexity to the general models of governance and often results in squabbles over allocations of housing and rights to development (Times of India, 2019).

In addition, Baugs will have to deal with issues regarding urban governance such as municipal provisions, fire safety codes, and heritage protection policies that need co-ordination with local and state government agencies (Azure Sky Follows, 2024).

- **Until 1900:** In the earlier days of Mumbai, the community welfare and housing of Parsis is handled mainly by the Bombay Parsi Punchayet (BPP) which has been constituted since 1672 and serves as the prime governing regulating body (FutureLearn, n.d.).

- **1899-1900:** British colonial administrators initiate the suburban development project on Dadar-Matunga-Wadala-Sion, as an outcome of the reform created by the plague. A Parsi civil engineer, Maneckji Edulji Joshi, bargains reserved plots and designs of Dadar Parsi Colony (Azure Sky Follows, 2024; Wikipedia, 2025).
- **1900s:** Philanthropic Parsi, most notably Bai Jerbai Wadia, who invest in construction of numerous Baugs, including Cusrow Baug and Ness Baug on government land leases and under trust administration (Parsikhabar.net, 2013).
- **Mid 1900s:** Trusts such as BPP formalize governance of responsibilities of rent, maintenance and handling of the interests among the tenants by institutionalizing the process to protect the interests and affordability of the community (Parsikhabar.net, 2013).
- **Late 1900s - Early 2000s:** The leases are about to expire, and the trusts become threatened with financial difficulties to balance between rent control and pay off the aging infrastructure (Times of India, 2019).
- **Of the 2010s,** there are legal wrangles over new lease extensions as government demands the big-value payment to renew Baugs on leased grounds, causing alarm to the future of Baugs and security of tenure (Times of India, 2019).
- **2013:** The BPP discontinues its previously existing housing scheme and looks at redevelopment which would involve potentially 20-40 storey buildings, a move which sparked debate in the community due to the considerations of heritage to be demolished and a modernization facet of a rapidly growing city (Times of India, 2013).
- **2020s:** Baug management is an exercise in striking a balance between maintaining history, accommodating as wide a range of financially viable residents as possible,

responding to infrastructure requirements and shepherding the public policy in the chaotic world of the modernized Mumbai (Azure Sky Follows, 2024).

6.5 Government and Public Authority Interventions.

Although Parsi Baugs have been mainly governed by community trusts and Bombay Parsi Punchayet (BPP), schemes, incentives and regulations established by different government and municipal agencies have a direct or indirect impact on such housing colonies. Such projects include demographic support schemes to city heritage protection and city services.

6.5.1 Jiyo Parsi Scheme

It is a central government initiative that was introduced by the Ministry of Minority Affairs in 2013-14, with the objective of reversing the decreasing trend of the Parsi community population. It comprises of medical support, advocacy and community health. Remarkably, it gives honorariums to the elderly members of Parsi Baugs taking care of children below the age of 10, meeting communities with families as the priority (Unisa & Bhagat, 2017; The Hindu).

6.5.2 Incentives related to Heritage conservation and building maintenance.

The municipal authorities and Mumbai Heritage Conservation Committee (MHCC) have provided benefits connected with heritage like tax relief and lower interest rates on loans to individual owners of heritage property. It is also suggested in the Development Plan 2014-2034 that there should be a special municipal fund to maintain the heritage buildings, and it may also be extended to the Baugs that is classified as heritage buildings (The Indian Express; Mumbai Mirror).

6.5.3 Incentives on Self-Redevelopment.

Maharashtra government has modeled policies to promote a Maharashtra government-led “self-redevelopment of older housing societies with tax rebates, subsidies, accelerated approvals and lessened transfer premiums. Although Baugs tend to be trust-based, as opposed to co-operative societies, this can be implemented to fit their redevelopment requirements (Mumbai Live).

6.5.4 Renewal and rent problems of leases.

Some of the large Baugs like Rustom, Jer, and Ness were demanded to pay large amounts of lease renewal to the government, which had been in the range of several crores. According to trustees, as nominal rent charitable institutions, Baugs should be not subject to such valuations, although this is a controversial policy area (Times of India, 2019).

6.5.5 Waste Management and Municipal Cooperation.

The Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) and other civic organizations have assisted Baugs to practice sustainability. An example is Godrej Baug which was recognized under the Swachh Bharat Mission in terms of waste separation and is seeking property tax rebates on environmentally friendly efforts (Hindustan Times).

6.5.6 Gaps and Policy Challenges

In spite of these interventions, there are still serious loopholes:

- ***Repair and maintenance financing:*** Government subsidies on old and dilapidated buildings.
- ***Burdens of lease renewals:*** High renewal charges put pressure on charitable trusts and tenants.

- ***Unclear heritage status:*** There are a lot of unprotected Baugs, which do not have formal heritage status to access benefits with conservation.
- ***Implementation delays:*** The implementation is done in a slow and inefficient way to water down the effect of redevelopment and conservation plans.
- ***Little customization:*** The largest part of the policies is general and not tailored to the trust-managed unique model of Baugs.

Section 7: Challenges and Future Outlook of Parsi Baugs Governance

7.1 Overview of Governance Challenges

Governance of Parsi Baugs has a number of challenges in the 21st century because of complicated lease-renewal, financial sustainability, community inclusivity and pressures of the contemporary urban modernization. Once administered by charitable trusts, notably the Bombay Parsi Punchayet (BPP) and other family trusts, Baugs are mainly located on government- leased property. Impending expirations of long-term leases (usually 99 years) and the resulting and expected financial reclamations of the governments have ignited legalistic conflicts and uncertainty about the future of such affordable housing enclaves (Times of India, 2019).

7.2 Lease Renewal and Financial Strain

Most Baugs were initially built close to a century ago on government leased land. Leap time approaching, trusts are being charged exorbitant rates to renew their leases as given in current market values that run into hundreds of crores of rupees in the case of some Baugs, Rustom Baug and Ness Baug (Times of India, 2019). This economic strain is at odds with the rent-controlled buildings possessed by the Baugs, where the rents paid by the tenants stay cheap to maintain affordability among the less wealthy Parsis (Parsikhabar.net, 2013).

Exceptions or preferential lease renewal provisions are voiced, by the trustees, to the said housing complexes on the basis of being engaged in charitable and social service. Various court battles and community movements occurred in order to demand fair terms of lease and preserve the character and purpose of the Baugs (Times of India, 2019).

7.3 Redevelopment Debates and Community Sentiments

Since some of these Baugs are aging infrastructurally and have issues with space traffic, there is an increasing call for redevelopment plans that include tearing-down low-rise houses in favor of new modern apartment buildings to accommodate greater numbers of families and modern provisions (Times of India, 2013). Driven by some trustees and younger Parsis, these proposals hold out the prospect of better living standards and possibly greater financial sustainability of the trusts.

This move is not going down well with a large number of the residents in the area, who feel reconstruction may weaken Baugs heritage, their green living environment and their cohesive social unit which is central to Parsi culture (Parsikhabar.net, 2013). Maintenance increases have also contributed to this resistance because there is an apprehension of them displacing the poorer residents.

7.4 The Way Forward: Adaptation of Governance and Governance Innovation

Striking a balance between these contradictory interests, the governance structures have to transform to include the concept of transparent decision-making, community involvement, and sustainable financial programs. It remains to be seen that new ideas like mixed income households, government and business collaboration, and heritage preservation tax breaks may comprise a multifaceted approach that will sustain Baugs and make developments such as Azure Sky Follows, 2024 remain viable (Azure Sky Follows, 2024).

Also included is reinforcement of legal provisions to accord Baugs the status of social housing and ensure adequate job security renewals of lease provisions. Resident associations in the governance and maintenance should be empowered to enhance community building and response to the needs of communities (Parsikhabar.net, 2013).

Section 8: Parsi Baugs by legacy and cultural significance

Baug in Mumbai represent more than just housing units but they are possibly the best relics of the Parsi community to its past philanthropy, social ethic and culture. Their heritage is evidence to the participation of the visionary community leaders and benefactors who wanted to give people affordable housing and at the same time maintained the religious as well as social customs of the people in a fast growing modernizing city (Times of India, 2024; Parsikhabar.net, 2013).

8.1 Historical Legacy and Philanthropic Foundations

The genesis of Baugs is intimately linked with the philanthropic spirit embodied by figures such as Bai Jerbai Wadia (1852-1926) who built several Baugs with an emphasis on an elegant architecture and having a community focus. The Wadia family together with other trusts developed five large Baugs in the years 1908-1956 of over 35 acres of prime South Mumbai land: Nowroz Baug (Lalbaug), Rustom Baug (Byculla), Bai Jerbai Baug (Byculla), Cusrow Baug (Colaba) and Ness Baug (Nana Chowk). All these Baugs were meant to house Parsis, who had a limited budget to depend upon to have a proper home of their own and social welfare and cultural welfare were taken into consideration along with the dire need of the house (Times of India, 2024).

Baug are historically shown to have helped in creating a distinct communal ecology of both religious spaces like fire temples and green spaces as well as sporting grounds and communal halls. They were the abridgements of many variable aspects like philanthropy,

architecture and culture- archives of the Parsi nation and their existence in the urbanistic lifestyle (Parsikhabar.net, 2013).

8.2 Trope- Symbols of Cultural Identity

The Baugs remain centers of the Parsi culture in a modernized and fast urbanizing Mumbai. The collective life of such Baugs promotes language and religious continuity of many generations as well as the family and community celebrations Gefoolz and others. The fire temples that are incorporated into Baugs have strong spiritual meaning and are constantly referred to as vessels of the Zoroastrian religion (Azure Sky Follows, 2024).

In addition, the Baugs embody ideals Parsi people have of charity (dana), social responsibility and community connectedness. This is evident in their self-management using trusts that control conflicts, the affordability of rent, and the organization of cultural activities that increase the collective identity through space and socialization (Parsikhabar.net, 2013).

8.3 Contemporary Cultural Challenges and Preservation Efforts

Although the Parsi Baugs hold great historical significance, they have been experiencing active threats and vulnerabilities to the community as a result of demographic decrease and financial problems. The declining population has made these small-scale colonies vulnerable and people fear losing their heritage as well as their heritages in terms of buildings and other estates (Hindustan Times, 2015).

There have been attempts of saving Baugs as living heritage sites with some advocating adaptive conservation programmes that keep Baugs architectural legacy and modernise facilities. Grass-roots campaigns to preserve and commemorate the histories of Baugs, coupled with pressure to enact ward-based policies to safeguard them, are an attempt to balance building preservation and adaptation (Parsikhabar.net, 2013).

Section 9: Parsi baugs and urban heritage in Mumbai

Parsi Baugs is a part of Mumbai urban heritage in itself as it brings out a very unique housing trend in addition to the contribution made by the Parsi community to the growth of Mumbai in terms of historical and cultural context. Their existence is the feature of interrelation of philanthropy, communal belonging, and city planning that formed the architectural, as well as social landscape of Mumbai.

9.1 Past Contributions to the growth of Mumbai.

It is because the Parsi community has played a central role in making Mumbai what it is in the modern times since its early colonial times. The Parsis are originally merchants and boat builders and they soon became money-lenders and industrialists who made a significant contribution to the economic growth of the city (Mumbai First, 2025). The community created houses, communities and important landmarks including Dadar Parsi Colony, Cusrow Baug and Malcolm Baug that demonstrated the interest of the group in structured living quarters, places of worship and community well being (Parsikhabar.net, 2013).

Families like the Wadias, Tatas, and the Jeejeebhoy are examples of industrial and philanthropic power, making their Baugs not only settlements but community and cultural, even social institutions that preserve the ethos of their kind (Mumbai First, 2025). Their architecture, typically colonial and neo-classical would leave a stamp of legacy in the form of heritage streetscapes in Mumbai

9.2 Urban Identity and Cultural Persistence

The Parsi Baugs are the bastion of cultural identity in the face of rapid urbanization of Mumbai. Their design is a low-rise structure consisting of gardens, fire temples, and community halls that would provide a heterogeneous spatial experience as compared to the rush of high-rise buildings provided by the urban setting (Azure Sky Follows, 2024). The

Baughs offer havens where Zoroastrian rituals, celebrations, social cultures and ways of life are still alive.

In addition, Baughs do not constitute neutral artefacts but vibrant societies in which ties of friendship, traditions, and shared memories are cultivated, which highlights the connection between space and identity (Parsikhabar.net, 2013). They share the social capital that maintains the Parsi community as unique in a multicultural city.

9.3 New issues of the Urban Legacy

Nonetheless, Baughs are under pressure since they are facing threats of urban development and demographic changes. His physical survival and the continuity of Parsi culture face threats due to encroachment through high rises of apartments, the alteration in land use policy as well as drop in Parsi population (Hindustan Times, 2015).

The discussions on redevelopment show a conflict between maintaining the heritage of Baughs and giving them a new life in order to meet contemporary living requirements which is part of a bigger tension in urban growth narrative in Mumbai as well. Declining populations and threatened, heritage require conservation expedited and creative housing paradigms designed to save the Baughs as living legacies not museum props.

Section 10: Conclusion

The Parsi Baughs of Mumbai are more than merely housing infrastructure; within them, providing more than material shelter, are social and historical tinder to the very existence of the Parsi community, its culture and the ways it is maintained through a fluid city. Baughs was born of the tradition of philanthropy, community welfare and cultural preservation and offered stable, but affordable housing to ensure the spiritual and recreational needs of Parsi identity were perpetuated through generations.

These Baugs provided relief to the housing pressure as well as were the places where the Parsi lifestyle, language, customs, religious practises and social networks were sustained in a tight knit physical space throughout the 20th century. Baugs were under the management of various trusts such as the Bombay Parsi Punchayet, and operated on a tricky model of rent control, long-term lease agreements, and community authority, so that even socially vulnerable Parsis could retain dignity and sense of place.

Nevertheless, the 21st century has something to offer that is overwhelming. Rent gradations at expiry of leases, rising land prices in urban areas, demographic stagnation and the central theme of modernization challenge the Baugs to issues of sustainability, equitability and conservation of heritage. With the changing housing market due to the impact of younger Parsis and other economically well off residents, governance structures are challenged to maintain Baugs as affordable housing options as well as centers of culture.

The future of the Parsi Baugs will depend on adaptive or adaptive governance, development of new forms of development that are sensitive to the heritage, and community engagement to maintain the socio-economic and cultural authenticity within the community. Baugs of Mumbai are living important socio-cultural resource and should be valued and preserved as an indelible trademark of a community that contributes so much of its civic identity to the urbanism of the city.

But the work of saving these historic enclaves does more than preserve buildings, and in the end that may be the most important thing at all, the legacy, the strength, the history of the Parsis of Mumbai will remain part of the story of the city going forward.

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